HILCHOT SHABBAT

Travel, Parties & Fasting: What Not to Do on Friday

Given Thursday 12 November 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat | Siman 249

Sefer: Shulhan Arukh, Orah Hayim, Hilchot Shabbat **Siman:** 249, seifim 1-4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Thursday Hilchot Shabbat class, Thursday 4 May 2023

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Skipping ahead to Friday

After the preparations for Shabbat in siman 242, the Rabbi skipped several chapters dealing with business partnerships between Jews and non-Jews and with travelling on ships, which are complex and not very relevant today. He noted in passing that taking a flight that will be in the air over Shabbat is "not simple at all", not least because at some point you will have to get off the plane and carry.

Siman 249 has four laws about Friday: travelling, festive meals, eating before Shabbat, and fasting.

Seif 1: long journeys on Friday

One should not travel on Friday more than three parsaot. A parsah is four mil, about 72 minutes of walking, so the limit is a journey of about three and a half hours.

The reason given here is not that you might come to break Shabbat. It is that you must arrive in time to prepare for Shabbat. Even if you are going to be someone's guest, Hazal wanted you to arrive in time to take part in the preparations.

The Shulhan Arukh adds that if the place where you are cannot provide for Shabbat, because it is a desert or not safe, you may travel as far as you need.

Why do people travel further today? - **They know you are coming.** The Shulhan Arukh says that if you sent word ahead that you are coming, so that they prepare for you, you may travel as far as you like. Today a phone call does this. - **Faster transport.** The Mishnah Berurah brings the Bah: the three and a half hours refers to walking. Travelling in a wagon (or a car) you may go further. - **Plenty of food.** The Magen Avraham says that nowadays people prepare generously, so a guest does not cause a shortage.

But the Mishnah Berurah adds a warning that the Rabbi stressed: do not travel too close to Shabbat. You may arrive and your hosts start cooking extra a few minutes before Shabbat, or you may arrive after dark and come to break Shabbat.

If Shabbat catches you on the way

- **On a train:** you may stay on. The difficulty is getting out of the station; the Rabbi described people who had to leave their travel card and walk home.
- **Driving:** you must stop. Every moment of driving is more Torah prohibitions. You stop at the nearest place that is safe, and spend Shabbat there if necessary.
- **Before Shabbat,** if you see you will not make it, you can leave the car and take a bus. The problem is getting off and carrying.

A ticket pinned onto your clothes is not considered carrying; it is part of your garment. In any case, the main lesson: always make sure to be on time.

The Rabbi also made a general point that came up here: "We don't make up our own marit ayin." People sometimes call something marit ayin only because they feel uncomfortable with it. One can sometimes argue that something is "ziluta deShabbat", cheapening Shabbat, and that depends on the purpose.

Seif 2: no big meals on Friday

It is forbidden to hold on Friday a feast that you would not normally have on a weekday, even a wedding meal. The Gemara in Gittin tells of a family in Jerusalem that used to hold its meals on Friday and did not last.

Three reasons are given: - The Shulhan Arukh: you should enter Shabbat with an appetite. - The Mishnah Berurah: it is a disgrace to Shabbat, making Friday equal to it. - You will be too busy with this meal to prepare properly for Shabbat.

Think of Purim falling on Friday: the house is a mess and no one can eat on Friday night. That is allowed only because the day fell then.

What is allowed: - The Rema: a meal whose time falls on Friday, such as a wedding that must take place then (with the huppah and yihud done before Shabbat), a Purim seudah, or a Brit Milah or Pidyon HaBen on its proper day. - A Brit Milah that was delayed and Friday is the first day it can be done may also have its seudah on Friday. But you may not choose to delay it to Friday when you could have done it on Thursday. - An engagement party on Friday is not allowed, but a small lehayim with some sweets and normal food is fine.

The Mishnah Berurah says that where such a seudah is permitted, it is good to hold it in the morning. The Rabbi explained that "misvah" in this context means "a nice thing", not a strict requirement.

Side point: there is a discussion whether a Brit Milah may be done on Thursday or Friday, since the third day is the most painful and may lead to desecrating Shabbat. It is questionable whether we hold this, and many mohalim allow it.

Seif 3: eating in the afternoon

Even without bread, eating a full meal's worth of food on Friday is permitted all day. But the Gemara says it is a misvah to stop from the ninth hour, three seasonal hours before Shabbat, so that you come to Shabbat with an appetite.

Which three hours? In the London summer, Shabbat comes in after 9pm but many accept it at about 7.15. Should one stop three hours before sunset or three hours before one actually brings in Shabbat? The Rabbi felt it is logical to count from when you bring Shabbat in, since the meal follows that. There are opinions either way.

The Mishnah Berurah's own point: these are seasonal hours, and in the winter they are short. The Rabbi's practical advice: this is a misvah, so decide what works for you. If you get hungry often, eat later; if one meal fills you for the day, eat very little on Friday.

Should you fast on Friday?

The Shulhan Arukh mentions pious people who fasted on Friday to come to Shabbat hungry. The Rabbi asked: is that honour for Shabbat, arriving starving and weak? The Mishnah Berurah (Shaar HaSiyun) says not to fast, so as not to enter Shabbat afflicted, unless you are someone who cannot eat at night if you eat during the day. The Ben Ish Hai rules this way too, and the Mishnah Berurah suggests that one who wants to fast should eat a little just before Shabbat.

"Don't eat too much on Friday. That's the main takeaway."

Seif 4: a fast accepted for Friday

If on Thursday afternoon you formally accepted a fast for Friday, you must fast until nightfall, even in the summer when that is very late. You cannot cut it short at Kiddush after shul.

If when accepting you said you would eat after shul, that works for your vow, since you are only bound by what you said. But it is not a halachic fast. A real taanit lasts the whole day until nightfall. Every fast begins at dawn; apart from Yom Kippur and Tisha BeAv there is no fast that begins the night before.

He mentioned that a Rishon (he thought the Maharam of Rothenburg) holds that when Asarah BeTevet falls on Friday one may end the fast before nightfall, and that Rav Ovadia Yosef relied on such opinions for someone who is not feeling well or feels faint.

Practical summary

- Do not set out so late on Friday that your hosts must cook at the last minute or you risk arriving after Shabbat begins.
- If Shabbat begins while you are driving, stop at the nearest safe place.
- Do not hold a large celebratory meal on Friday unless its time falls then (wedding, Brit Milah on time, Purim).
- It is a misvah to avoid a big meal in the last three hours before Shabbat, so you come to Shabbat with an appetite.
- Do not fast on Friday unless you are someone who cannot eat at night otherwise.
- A fast formally accepted for Friday must be kept until nightfall.

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